

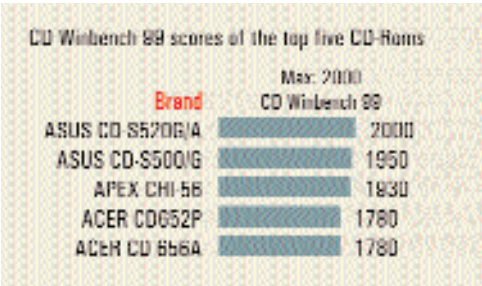
TEST PROCESS

The tests comprised of a mix of real-world and synthetic benchmarks that included Ziff-Davis CD Winbench 99, SiSoft Sandra 2001, AudioCatalyst (digital audio encoding).

The real world tests included copying a single 100 MB file, copying 100 MB of assorted smaller files, and opening 10 TIFF images through Photoshop 6.0.

The weightages accorded to these tests in determining the overall performance of the drives are given in the adjoining table.

Tests	Weightages
CD Winbench 99	10
SiSoft Sandra 2001te	34
SiSoft index	4
Sequential read (KB/s)	10
Random read (KB/s)	10
Average access time (ms)	10
Audio catalyst	24
File copy / access	32
Single 100 MB (sec)	8
Assorted files (sec)	12
Opening files in Photoshop (sec)	12



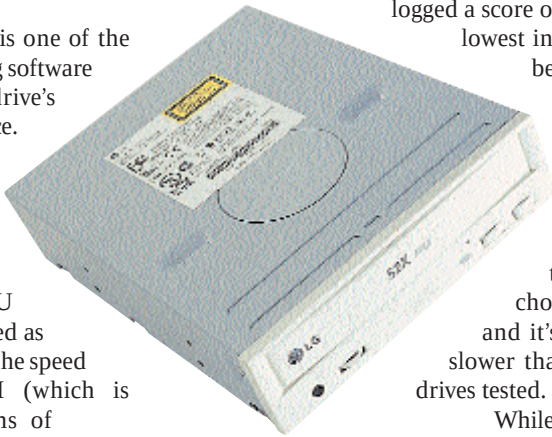
access times). As this test involves running a variety of applications such as word processors and spreadsheets that are run directly from the Winbench 99 CD, you get a clear indication of performance while working with these 'real world' applications as well as the actual data transfer speeds. Since this test continuously accesses the drive, the operating noise levels of the drive also becomes evident.

In this test the drive that overtook all others was the **ASUS CD-S520/G**. Though the rated speed of this drive was just 52x, it outperformed other higher rated drives by scoring an index of 2000—the highest in this test. Coming in a close second to this drive was its sibling, the ASUS CD-S500, which logged a score of 1950.

Of notable mention is the Apex CHI-56, which trailed 70 points behind the fastest drive in this test. However, the price of this drive is a very significant Rs 400 lesser than the 52x ASUS, with performance that closely matches it.

On the lower side, the drive that didn't meet up with our expectations was the 40x Plextor PX-40TSi. Sporting a SCSI interface, this drive logged a score of just 1380, which was the lowest in this roundup. In spite of being rated as a 40x drive, this one came with a Rs 5,450 price tag because of its SCSI interface. With performance that was just not up to the mark in this test, this drive is not a good choice: its price is a constraint and it's performance is, in fact, slower than even some of the IDE drives tested.

While most scores posted by the 52x drives ranged from 1500 to



sport a blazingly fast 72x maximum read speed! While these speeds are not sustained throughout the entire operation of the drive, the effective read speeds of the CD-ROM drives available today will let you, for example, install Windows 98SE in about 35 minutes flat on a Pentium III based system, as compared to the leisurely 50 minutes to one hour that it used to take on the 32x and slower drives available just a few years ago.

To help you better understand the potential of these bad boys, we've put to test some of the best CD-ROM drives available today to help you get a good idea of the kind of myriad applications each is capable of running.

Application tests

CD Winbench 99 is one of the best benchmarking software for testing a CD drive's overall performance. This includes measuring the CPU power utilised while operating the CD-ROM (that is CPU utilisation expressed as a percentage) and the speed of the CD-ROM (which is expressed in terms of data transfer rates and

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More Info on the test process and the products tested.

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